STRATS

A Game of Victory and Deception

OBJECTIVE

Be the last player with cards by winning battles through strategic deception.

SETUP

1. Shuffle the full deck (52 cards + 2 jokers)
2. Deal all cards evenly to all players. If cards remain, reveal them to all players, then discard them
3. Randomly determine the first Broker

GAMEPLAY

Each turn has three phases:

PHASE 1: DRAW

- Every player draws 3 cards from the top of their deck and looks at them privately
- Keep these separate from your deck

PHASE 2: REVEAL

Starting with the Broker and proceeding clockwise, each player chooses:

Option A: Reveal

- Show one card face-up to all players
- This card is locked for battle (you MUST play it)

Option B: Finish

- Declare you're done revealing
- Choose battle cards: MUST include all revealed cards, MUST play at least 1 card, MAY include unrevealed cards
- Push chosen cards face-down to the center
- Return unchosen cards to the bottom of your deck

Continue clockwise until all players have finished.

PHASE 3: BATTLE

1. Reveal

Once all players have finished, everyone flips their battle cards face-up.

2. Card Values

- Ace = 1
- Number cards = Face value
- Jack = 11
- Queen = 12
- King = 13
- Joker = No value, reduces cap by 5 (does not stack)

3. Scoring

- Base cap = 20
- You can **not** play a value past 20 (no self busting)
- A joker played by ANY player reduces the cap by 5
- Add up your card values
- **If your total exceeds the cap, your score is -1**

4. Winner

- Highest score wins
- Score of 0 (only jokers) beats -1 (busted)

5. Collecting Cards

Winner:

- Collects all battle cards and shuffles them face-down
- Randomly draws half (rounded up), looks at them privately, and places them at the bottom of their deck
- Remaining cards are discarded face-down (never revealed)

Tie:

- Tied players divide pool evenly (same process as winner)
- Remainder cards are discarded face-down

Next Turn: The player clockwise from the current Broker becomes the new Broker.

ELIMINATION & VICTORY

- When a player runs out of cards, they are eliminated
- **The last player with cards wins**

STRATEGY

- Finishing early hides information but locks your choice
- Waiting to finish gives information but may force suboptimal plays
- Playing only jokers is risky but wins if everyone else busts
- Track played cards to estimate opponents' remaining hands